Basu as chief minister, these riots were controlled by Kolkata police immediately.

Rajiv was received at New Delhi airport by Arun Nehru. Both left for AIIMS in the same car. What transpired between them is not fully known. One of the subjects discussed was obviously Rajiv's appointment as PM. As relations between Indira Gandhi and President Zail Singh had soured, especially after Operation Blue Star, Arun Nehru wanted Vice President R. Venkataraman to administer the oath of office to Rajiv Gandhi before the arrival of President Zail Singh, who was away on a state visit.

Zail Singh, who learnt the shocking news while on his way from Mauritius to Yemen, diverted his plane to New Delhi. At AIIMS, P.C. Alexander was able to convince Rajiv Gandhi to wait for President Zail Singh's arrival. Pranab Mukherjee left for 1 Akbar Road at around 4.10 p.m. in Arun Nehru's car, Kamal Nath being another passenger in the car. Meanwhile, President Zail Singh's plane landed at around 5 p.m., and he went straight to AIIMS, where his car was stoned and one of his staff members manhandled.

Around 6.30 p.m., Zail Singh administered the oath of office as prime minster to Rajiv Gandhi and four members of his cabinet – Pranab Mukherjee, P.V. Narasimha Rao, P. Shiv Shankar and Buta Singh.

M.L. Fotedar continued to hold the fort at 1 Akbar Road. It was only after his position as political secretary to the PM was confirmed with the appointment of Rajiv Gandhi as PM and Narsimha Rao as home minister that Fotedar called Rao on the phone and told him that for better coordination, 1 Akbar Road was taking over control of Delhi Police. While some scattered anti-Sikh riots had broken out even earlier – for instance, around AIIMS and the INA bridge – a large-scale coordinated pogrom now followed. It started from Kidwai Nagar, not very far from AIIMS and the INA bridge.

That such an eventuality had been foreseen could be borne out by the fact that on 31 October goons were carrying voters' lists to identify Sikh homes, [2] and some Congress leaders were supplying them with old car tyres, kerosene, oil and other incendiary material that would be used to burn Sikhs alive.